WITS AHEAD RESEARCH GROUP

The AHEAD Fortnightly

Issue 2 · 15 October 2026 · Wits School of Education, University of the Witwatersrand

This fortnight the question shifted from whether universities should engage with artificial intelligence to how they decide. Minister Buti Manamela told the Universities South Africa conference that it is time to move from debate to decisions on teaching and research, and two Wits computer scientists in the RAIL Lab argued that Africa must set its own AI research agenda rather than only apply tools built elsewhere. Meanwhile, universities abroad are stepping back from AI detectors and from Turnitin's proposed licence terms, a reminder that trust and judgement cannot be outsourced to software. For us at Wits AHEAD, these are the decisions that build human capability, and this issue reaches you in thirteen languages.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1

NEWS · 14 OCTOBER 2026 · GLOBAL

Joining up AI across recruitment, retention and alumni relations can close graduation gaps, if it is governed well

Writing in University World News, IREX project director Cameron Mirza argues universities should treat recruitment, retention and alumni relations as one connected, AI supported lifecycle rather than separate systems with separate data. He cites Georgia State University's chatbot and predictive analytics programme, credited with cutting "summer melt" by about 21 per cent and with helping Black, Hispanic, first generation and low income students graduate at rates matching or exceeding the wider student body, while warning that models trained on historical data can also entrench the inequities they are meant to fix.

> **Why it matters:** For Wits AHEAD's pillar on AI and predictive analytics for student success, the piece is a useful reminder that early warning and retention tools only close equity gaps when they are paired with human oversight and bias testing, exactly the governance question Wits AHEAD asks of any analytics tool it recommends.

University World News · universityworldnews.com · Read at source

Mirza, C. (2026, October 14). How AI improves student recruitment, retention, advancement. *University World News*. universityworldnews.com/post.php?story=20261014130619431

2

NEWS · 13 OCTOBER 2026 · SOUTH AFRICA

Wits researchers argue Africa must set its own AI research agenda, not just apply others' tools

Two University of the Witwatersrand computer scientists, Benjamin Rosman and Steve James, who co-direct the Robotics, Autonomous Intelligence and Learning (RAIL) Lab, argue that Africa should drive artificial intelligence research rather than only apply tools built elsewhere. They point to the Deep Learning Indaba, now the world's largest AI summer school, which drew 1,300 participants to last year's gathering in Kigali and runs its IndabaX programme in 48 of Africa's 54 countries this year, and to Wits's new Machine Intelligence and Neural Discovery (MIND) Institute, which brings together about 65 academics across computer science, neuroscience, psychology and policy.

> **Why it matters:** For Wits AHEAD's pillar on responsible AI, ethics, equity and policy, the warning against Africa becoming merely "a site for other people to do science" speaks directly to Wits AHEAD's own mission of building African led capability to set AI research questions, not only to use AI tools designed elsewhere.

Times Higher Education · timeshighereducation.com · Read at source

Luckhurst, G. (2026, October 13). Africa has crucial role in advancing study of AI, say professors. *Times Higher Education*. timeshighereducation.com/news/africa-has-crucial-role-advancing-study-ai-say-professors

3

NEWS · 9 OCTOBER 2026 · UNITED KINGDOM

More universities end Turnitin contracts as concerns mount

Times Higher Education reports that Newcastle University and the University of Westminster have joined the University of Southampton in ending their contracts with the plagiarism-detection company Turnitin, after it proposed licence changes that could have let student coursework be used to train AI tools. Newcastle cited that data clause directly; Westminster said Turnitin's plagiarism checker was "largely ineffective" against AI-written text and its AI detector carried "a recognised risk of false positives". Southampton alone paid Turnitin £87,621 in one year, out of a student body of over 17,000 undergraduates and 8,000 postgraduates.

> **Why it matters:** For Wits AHEAD's pillar on responsible AI, ethics, equity and policy, the dispute shows universities starting to weigh data governance and the real reliability of AI-detection tools against cost, rather than treating a plagiarism-checking contract as a fixed necessity.

Times Higher Education · timeshighereducation.com · Read at source

Luckhurst, G. (2026, October 9). More universities end Turnitin contracts as concerns mount. *Times Higher Education*. timeshighereducation.com/news/more-universities-end-turnitin-contracts-concerns-mount

RESEARCH AND REPORTS

Prepare students for post-graduation AI judgement challenges

University World News · 9 October 2026 · Pillar 4: Graduate capability and just transitions. For Wits AHEAD's pillar on AI, graduate capability, employability and just transitions, the finding that confident but wrong AI-assisted work can read as convincingly as correct work points to professional judgement, not AI literacy alone, as the capability graduates most need before they enter the labour market.

Nguyen, P. (2026, October 9). Prepare students for post-graduation AI judgement challenges. *University World News*. universityworldnews.com/post.php?story=20261009115040153

South African minister tells universities to move from AI debate to decisions on teaching and research

South African Government News Agency (SAnews) · 8 October 2026 · Pillar 1: Generative AI in higher education. For Wits AHEAD's pillar on generative AI in higher education, a cabinet minister setting out a concrete agenda, on teaching, assessment and research capacity rather than general debate, gives South African universities a clear mandate to act on.

South African Government News Agency. (2026, October 8). *Universities challenged to prepare graduates for AI-driven future*. SAnews. sanews.gov.za/node/84823

Study of students in China, Japan and Mongolia finds access to generative AI does not guarantee it is useful for learning

arXiv (working paper) · 4 October 2026 · Pillar 1: Generative AI in higher education. For Wits AHEAD's pillar on generative AI in higher education, the finding that language and local technology conditions, not connectivity alone, decide whether generative AI genuinely helps students learn is a caution Wits AHEAD applies equally to English dominant AI tools used across multilingual Southern African campuses.

Li, M., Xie, Q., Enkhtur, A., Chen, L., & Cheng, F. (2026). From access to realized affordances: University students' generative AI engagement across linguistic and sociotechnical contexts. *arXiv*. arxiv.org/abs/2610.05301

FROM THE GROUP

12 Sep 2026 **Doctoral thesis completed; candidate to graduate in December 2026**
Examiner-required corrections accepted on a study of highly successful distance-learning students in East African higher education.

12 Sep 2026 **Masters research report completed with distinction; candidate to graduate in December 2026**
A bibliometric review of data-driven leadership and policy design; the next step is a doctoral proposal.

A READING WE PROFFER

Development as Freedom Amartya Sen, Oxford University Press (1999). The H in AHEAD. Start here.

With best wishes for the fortnight ahead,



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